



Research paper

Examining professional ideology through the perspectives of higher education professionals

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ARTICLE INFO

Keywords:

Professional ideologies
Professional practices
Private higher education
Qualitative research
Pedagogical practices

ABSTRACT

Recent societal changes have sparked a growing interest in teachers' professional ideologies and pedagogical practices in higher education. Our qualitative study examines how market-driven private higher education impacts teachers' professional ideologies. We have employed thematic analysis to interpret our data and generate themes. The themes explore eight teachers' diverse views on professional ideology, its importance in teaching, and the societal perception of private higher education. Participants also expressed concerns about the commercialization of higher education and societal biases against private universities. The study recommends implementing specialized management strategies and awareness campaigns to foster a professional culture that aligns with educational goals.

1. Introduction

Since the 1980s, universities have been pressured to adopt commercial models that highlights knowledge commercialization, employability skills, outcome-based curriculum and corporate management structure (Altabach et al., 2019; Jung & Yonezawa, 2017; Lorenz, 2012; Mok & Marginson, 2021; Rumbley et al., 2022; Selenica, 2018). One important consequence of this transformation is the decline of the traditional understanding of the role of teaching and the professional ideology of educators. Market-driven education often prioritizes commercial goals over educational values, leading to a deterioration in the standards of higher education and an undermining of teachers' professional ideologies (Kezar & Bernstein-Sierra, 2023). In market-driven higher education, financial considerations can sometimes overshadow the traditional values of teachers' professional ideologies, such as a commitment to academic excellence and a genuine passion for teaching. This commodification of education has resulted in a scenario where the core values of higher education, including the intrinsic motivations and ethical commitments of educators, are increasingly compromised (Brennan et al., 2004, p. 72; Marginson, 2018). The prioritization of effectiveness, productivity, and quantifiable results frequently results in

the undervaluation of the qualitative factors related to education, including creativity, critical thinking, and the development of a holistic learning environment (Ball, 2012).

Additionally, this change has had an effect on teachers' professional identities and teaching practices. Teachers are now expected to follow to rigorous curricula, standardized testing, and performance metrics that prioritize tangible results over the diverse needs of their students. Critical theorists, such as Giroux (2017) argue that this administrative approach undermines teachers' autonomy, hindering their ability to innovate and promote critical engagement and deeper learning. Apple, (2017) supports this view, highlighting that such policies erode the guiding principles in higher education, significantly impacting student learning outcomes and teachers' professional practices. The attention on immediately employable skills and marketable skills often ignores the broader developmental and transformative potential of higher education (Milley, 2016). Our arguments on these observation builds on Apple's and Giroux's theories, asserting that the commercialization and commodification of education fundamentally alter the professional ideologies of teachers, thereby affecting the holistic development of students. Therefore, the current market-driven approach in higher education necessitates a re-evaluation of the balance between financial

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Received 12 April 2024; Received in revised form 19 July 2024; Accepted 4 September 2024

Available online 23 September 2024

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demands and the preservation of educational ideals and professional ideology (Satti & Saba, 2024). Consequently, the commercialization of higher education has significantly transformed the role of teaching and teachers' professional ideologies. The focus on financial gain in higher education has led to a decline in academic standards and a loss of teachers' professional identities. The trend emphasizes the need for a renewed emphasis on the intrinsic values of education and the professional autonomy of educators for holistic student development and educational integrity. Thus, the commercialization of higher education has led to a decline in academic standards and disrupted teachers' professional ideologies, requiring a fresh focus on education's fundamental ideals and professional autonomy. This argument aligns with Giroux's (2017) advocacy for educational spaces that prioritize critical pedagogy and resist market pressures.

Regardless of the global presence of commercial private higher education institutions around the world, the rapid growth of private higher education in the Asian region has become a cause for concern. This trend holds even with variations in socioeconomic policies, levels of development, and overall impact (Altbach et al., 2019; Gupta, 2018; Mok & Marginson, 2021). The justification of private higher education may be questioned based on the classroom pedagogical grounds and teachers' professional ideology (Connell, 2009). Our perspective builds on the critical theories of Apple and Giroux to understand the ramifications of these commercial trends in the Asian context, particularly in terms of professional ideologies and private educational practices. The study, therefore, examines teachers' professional ideology and pedagogical practices in private higher education in the lower-middle class Asian societies. The rising demand for private higher education among Asian parents is driven by perceived necessity and the increasing demand for such institutions (Altbach et al., 2019). Despite its widespread acceptance, especially in countries like India, Bangladesh, many have recently raised concerns about the professional ideologies and involvement of teachers in private higher education (Hamid et al., 2015; Islam, 2013; Nurunnabi, 2018). These concerns highlight the need to critically evaluate the impact of private higher education on educational quality and the professional integrity of educators (Jung & Yonezawa, 2017; Rumbley et al., 2022).

To date, limited studies have focused on teachers' professional ideology, though some researchers have highlighted the need for further examination in this area (Chau et al., 2022; Evetts, 2013; Hall & McGinity, 2015; Knowles & Castro, 2019). Kwo and Bray (2014) rightly noted in their study that, despite the longstanding visibility of teachers' professional ideology in much of East and South Asia, researchers have been slow to address this phenomenon. Consequently, the present study aims to explore teachers' understanding and practices of professional ideologies in relation to their classroom pedagogical practices. This perspective not only facilitates the exploration of professionalism in teaching but also contributes to a deeper theoretical understanding of the phenomenon (Evans, 2008). To understand the professional ideology of teaching in the context of contemporary private higher education practices, this study considers the concept of teachers' ideologies, addressing issues that have been overlooked by previous research. While numerous studies have examined the nature, scale, and costs of classroom teaching, fewer have focused on its ideological dimensions, underscoring the importance of this investigation (Clegg, 2008).

Our interpretivist research (Elliot et al., 2016) examines data collected through interviews, problematizing teachers' professional ideology in relation to their classroom pedagogical practices at private higher education institutions. Data were gathered from professionals working at various private universities in Dhaka, the capital city of a lower-middle-income country in Asia (Islam et al., 2023). Utilizing convenience sampling, as suggested by Rivera (2019), we selected participants for the study. The guiding question is, "How do teachers understand their professional ideologies in relation to their classroom pedagogical practices at private higher education institutions in Dhaka?" To address this, we aim to provide a deeper understanding of how

teachers perceive their professional ideologies and explain their pedagogical practices within the context of private higher education in Bangladesh. Our perspective aligns with Apple's (2017) critique of neoliberal educational policies, emphasizing the need to understand how these policies impact teachers' professional ideologies and practices. Our findings highlight that teachers in these institutions emphasize continual professional development to align their educational practices with the concept of teachers' professionalism.

1.1. Teacher professional ideology and private higher education

The notion of teacher professional ideology is difficult to define and somewhat complex to explain. For this reason, it is essential to trace notions of teacher professional ideology with regard to shifting historical, political and social contexts because several meanings have been developed with a long history, and are commonly discussed on sociological, educational and ideological basis in the literature (Demirkasimoğlu, 2010). But still, this phenomenon is the subject of many academic debates from different socio-cultural perspectives. When the subject is professional ideology, the meaning of the term varies as a response to external pressures, public discourses, and socio-cultural developments. Therefore, teachers' professional ideology can play an important role in unveiling the reality of teaching profession. Our perspective on professional ideology builds on the work of Evetts (2013), who identifies teachers' professional ideology as a crucial idea which consciously inspires collective or individual efforts, but also a mystification which unconsciously exposes real social structures and relations. Our perspective on professional ideology also acknowledges the need to consider both conscious and unconscious elements in understanding it. The study of private higher education's teaching practices through an ideological lens provides a valuable perspective to understand the teaching profession and its complexities. That is, teachers' professional ideologies prominently impact their engagement and practices in higher education. Therefore, examining the relationship between current commercial models of education and the higher education teaching profession is crucial for understanding teachers' professional ideologies. For instance, according to Cohen (2005), teachers' professional ideologies are shaped by their perceptions and understanding of education, along with their roles as teachers. Our professional ideology perspective aligns with Cohen's notion that perceptions and understanding play a critical crucial role in shaping professional ideologies, particularly in the context of commercialization. Hence, the commercialization of these institutions raises significant concerns about the alignment of teachers' professional ideologies with the professional dilemma from the core values of teaching-learning practices.

Recent studies reveal that teachers' motivations and understandings in market-driven private higher education are firmly connected to their professional ideologies (e.g., McAllister-Grande, 2011; Mok & Marginson, 2021; Rumbley et al., 2022). In such market-driven environments, teachers' decision-making processes and professional ideologies have significantly been influenced when it comes to working in private institutions (i.e., Hazelkorn, 2015; Pérez-Encinas, 2019). We concur with Hazelkorn and Perez-Encinas that market demands substantially influences teachers' professional decisions and ideologies. For example, Private universities, driven by market demands, often offer greater flexibility in curriculum development and instructional strategies, appealing to teachers who value academic freedom and creative teaching methods (Stensaker et al., 2011). Because of this flexibility, teachers can modify their pedagogical strategies to better suit their professional beliefs, which place a high value on individualized instruction and student participation. This aligns with Stensaker et al.'s findings that flexibility can enhance teachers' ability to align their practices with their professional beliefs. As a result, rather than prioritizing the conventional value of teaching and teachers' professional ideology, private universities can provide supportive and welcoming learning environments that emphasize student-centred learning

practices (Chen et al., 2022; Wang & Li, 2023). Our perspective is in agreement with Chen et al. and Wang & Li that student-centred practices are crucial for supporting teachers' professional goals in private higher education. Thus, Private higher education, driven by market forces, influences institutional functioning, supports teachers' professional goals, and fosters an environment conducive to both teacher and student success.

In the Asian context, teachers in private universities need to pay more attention to student voices compared to their counterparts in publicly funded universities. This emphasis on student-centred approaches reflects the greater flexibility in curriculum development and instructional strategies often found in private universities, which appeal to teachers who value academic freedom and innovative teaching methods (Maassen & Stensaker, 2011). On the contrary, teachers who prioritize stability and job security might opt for public funded universities with well-established administrative structures (Hazelkorn, 2015). We agree with Maassen & Stensaker and Hazelkorn that the choice between private and public institutions often depends on individual teachers' priorities, whether it be flexibility and innovation or stability and security. These contrasting environments highlight a complex relationship between teachers' professional beliefs and their decision-making in the private higher education institutions. In fact, Private university growth and development are influenced by societal expectations, government regulations, and market demands (Marginson, 2016). Societal expectations shape the types of programs that private universities prioritize, while government regulations often determine the operational framework within which these institutions must function. Market demands, including student demand and competition from other institutions, also significantly impact decision-making processes at private universities (Rumbley et al., 2022). We agree with Marginson and Rumbley et al. that societal expectations, regulations, and market demands are key factors shaping private universities and teachers' professional ideologies. Together, these outside forces mould the professional ideology of teachers working in the private higher education industry. Research has demonstrated, for example, that teachers' understandings in market-driven private higher education are strongly correlated with their professional beliefs (e.g., Mok & Marginson, 2021). Because these institutions are dynamic, teachers must adjust to the shifting requirements and preferences of their students, which frequently calls for a more individualized approach to teaching and learning (Khan et al., 2023). We build on the work of Mok & Marginson and Khan et al. to emphasize the need for adaptability and individualized teaching approaches in market-driven educational environments. This adaptability of private universities is vital for their continued relevance and competitiveness in the rapidly changing educational landscape.

Overall, to understand the connection between teachers' professional ideologies and private higher education, it is necessary to conduct a detailed analysis of their motivations, perspectives, and the contextual factors that influence their beliefs and values. Previous research has highlighted the importance of professional ideologies in guiding teachers' decision-making and practices within the private sector (e.g., Connolly & Hughes-Stanton, 2020). We align with Connolly & Hughes-Stanton in recognizing the guiding role of professional ideologies in teachers' practices. By delving deeper into this relationship, scholars and policymakers can gain valuable insights into the intricate nature of teaching in private higher education and develop a more comprehensive understanding of the market-driven dynamics of these institutions.

2. Overview of private higher education in Bangladesh

While private higher education has been around for quite some time (Altbach, 2013), there is no universally accepted definition for the term "private university." Public is frequently linked with government, state ownership whereas private is frequently associated with the enterprise,

or nonprofit organizations, whose ownership is private (Marginson, 2007). Higher education in Bangladesh was first seen as a public good that should be offered for free by public universities. However, the early 1990s were characterized by rising demand for higher education, insufficient expansion of public higher education, and constrained funding for public universities. These factors combined to create the ideal environment for the expansion of private universities. As a result, private higher education has grown since 1990 and has finally taken a significant role in the delivery of higher education. It took nearly ten years to make the recommendations into parliamentary legislation in 1992 when the first private university in the nation was authorized by the government to open. As of 2023, there are 112 private universities in Bangladesh (UGCB, 2023).

The expansion of private universities is a result of consumers' demand for higher education in a market where state universities fall short in both number and quality. Students are, therefore, prepared to pay for private higher education (Ahmed, 2016). However, there are a number of reasons why universities have switched from being entirely public to being private. These factors include neo-liberal ideology, economic restraint, and pressure from international organizations, such as the World Bank (Teixeira & Amaral, 2001). The late 1980s and early 1990s saw the growth of private universities in Bangladesh due to the liberalization of the economy and the Private University Act of 1992. Therefore, Bangladesh's private universities' growth is attributed to the high demand for higher education, supportive government frameworks, and eager investors, similar to other developing nations.

In the field of higher education, private institutions are experiencing the most rapid expansion (Islam, 2013, with variations in both ownership and orientation among them. The development and growth of this industry demonstrate two key aspects: firstly, the willingness of parents to support their children's education, and secondly, the success of these institutions in meeting public expectations. As of 2023, private universities had over 45,000 students, a significant increase in enrollment. Around 4500 educators work in the private universities in Bangladesh (UGCB, 2023). Around 60% of faculty members are full-time, with many part-time teachers being appointed from public universities. Private institutions in Bangladesh are primarily recognized for their ability to provide education at minimal public expense.

3. Methods

In our study, we employed a qualitative methodology (Creswell, 2018; Denzin, 2019) to interpret the statements and understandings of participants involved in current teaching practices within private higher education in Dhaka, Bangladesh. Our key research question guided the data collection and analysis, focusing on understanding the intricate dynamics of teachers' professional ideologies in these educational settings. This approach ensured coherence between our research aim and methodology. Additionally, our perspective as full-time faculty members influenced our interpretation, providing insider insights into the academic environment and professional practices.

In this study, we employed semi-structured interviews as our method of data collection. This approach has been demonstrated to be highly effective in addressing the specific problem of our study (Holmqvist & Frisén, 2012; Marvasti & Trevino, 2019). Our semi-structured interviews consisted of asking open-ended questions to encourage dialogue and gather the perspectives and insights of the participants (Braun & Clarke, 2012). We analysed the information gathered from the interviews, identified recurring words as codes, and highlighted significant portions of each transcript for our coding technique. By using themes derived from the interview transcripts, we were able to convey the participants' opinions, providing a basis for other higher education professionals to comprehend.

3.1. Participants recruitment

The study aims to understand the application of the system to individuals and how private higher education in Bangladesh influences teachers’ professional ideologies. The participants had to.

- 1. Be a full-time faculty member in a private higher education in Bangladesh.
- 2. Have at least five years of working experiences in a private higher education in Bangladesh.
- 3. Be able to articulate teachers’ professionalism and professional ideology based on Bangladeshi private higher education.

After obtaining clearance from the institutional review board, we chose six university teachers from three different private universities in Dhaka. These teachers had diverse academic backgrounds, academic disciplines, teaching experiences, and educational profiles. Detailed demographic information about the participants can be found in Table 1. We identified potential participants through our networks and also used a snowballing technique. After three months of searching, we found 18 teachers who met our selection criteria. Finally, we selected eight teachers for the study. The interviews were conducted by the first author, who is fluent in both Bangla and English. This allowed the interviewees to freely switch between the two languages based on their comfort level in expressing their ideas. The interviews primarily focused on the teachers’ experiences and understanding of private university teaching. They discussed various reasons for choosing this profession, including higher salaries, social status, limited opportunities in public universities, and the impact of globalization.

We used the qualitative method to examine the complexities of teachers’ professional ideologies among private university teachers (Merriam, 2009). This method helped to gain insights into the characteristics of the situation, including participant attitudes, values, experiences, and aspirations. A small sample size of six participants was appropriate for this research because it allowed researchers to listen to the participants’ experiences and understand the factors that influenced their decision to teach at a private university in Bangladesh.

3.2. Semi-structured interviews

To facilitate in-depth dialogue with the participants over an extended period, a semi-structured interview approach was employed. The semi-structured interview is a widely used method for gathering data that incorporates the perspectives of the respondents (Creswell, 2009). Face-to-face interviews were conducted in this study to explore how participants reflected on their experiences. The interviews primarily focused on participants’ understanding of the challenges faced by teachers in private universities in Bangladesh, including low salaries, diminished social status, and eroding authority. These factors have compelled teachers to grapple with changing roles alongside their professional ideologies. By employing the qualitative method (Merriam, 2009), this study sought to delve into the complexities of each teacher’s professional ideology within the context of private universities. This approach facilitated a deeper understanding of participants’ attitudes,

values, experiences, and aspirations.

3.3. Materials and procedure

The main method used for data collection was individual interviews. In-depth interviews were conducted using semi-structured questions to ensure that the researchers obtained detailed and thoughtful responses (DeJonckheere and Vaughn, 2019). The researchers intentionally selected private university teachers who are currently teaching and informed them about the research problem. This enabled the teachers to provide a nuanced and meaningful understanding of the phenomenon. Additionally, the researchers were able to delve deeper into teacher professionalism and ideologies as they had been teaching at these universities for a significant time. Their extensive experience allowed them to develop a profound understanding of the teaching and learning practices in private higher education institutions in Bangladesh. To maintain ethical standards, pseudonyms were used for all participants.

We conducted face-to-face, semi-structured interviews to gain insights from the participants regarding the study problem. We developed an interview guide/protocol with two sections focused on the research questions. These questions addressed university teachers’ understanding of their professional ideology about private higher education practices and participation in private university teaching. We used interview questions to probe the relevant dimensions of the research questions. For example, in the first section of the interview, we asked about teachers’ involvement in teaching in private universities. In the second part of the interview, we asked participants to elaborate on their ideas regarding professional ideologies in private higher education. One of the contributors to this paper conducted 40–50-min interviews with each participant on the campus of their respective universities. The interviews were recorded and later transcribed.

3.4. Analysis

This study employed thematic analysis (Braun & Clarke, 2012) to examine the data collected through semi-structured interviews. Initially, all interviews were transcribed verbatim immediately after they were conducted. The researchers then reviewed the transcripts for accuracy. After becoming familiar with the data through transcription and multiple readings of each interview, data analysis was carried out using the axial coding process (Saldana, 2016) with the assistance of Nvivo-10, a qualitative software program. The coding process is used to organize different aspects of the data, allowing for specific pieces of data to be retrieved and used to answer research questions. It also helps to refine a list of codes that identify the main ideas of the study. The formulated meanings are then grouped into themes, which reveal common themes across all participants’ transcripts. In other words, the researchers developed clusters of meaning from significant statements and organized them into themes. These themes became the major findings of the study. To ensure that the key points were captured, regardless of the specific questions asked, the themes were selected based on how frequently certain topics were mentioned during the interviews.

The analysis was conducted inductively, with the most relevant topics extracted from the data (Braun & Clarke, 2012). The first author

Table 1
Demographic information of participants: (N) indicates the number of participants.

Pseudo (N)	Age (Years)	Gender	Teaching Subjects	Academic qualifications	Teaching Experiences	Designation
T1	41	Male	English	Pursuing PhD	15	Associate Professor
T2	40	Male	Anthropology	MSS	14	Senior Lecturer
T3	28	Female	English	MA	3	Lecturer
T4	39	Female	English	MA	13	Lecturer
T5	26	Male	Accounting	MA	2	Senior Lecturer
T6	47	Male	Physics	PhD	21	Associate Professor
T7	36	Male	English	MA	6	Lecturer
T8	38	Male	English	MA	7	Lecturer

coded the theme analysis, but the other authors also discussed the codes. After that, the researchers integrated the results into a detailed and comprehensive description of the professional ideology phenomenon. Finally, to enhance the credibility, dependability, and transparency of the findings (Lincoln & Guba, 1985), the researchers validated the findings with the participants and incorporated their feedback and corrections.

3.5. Trustworthiness

According to Jones, Torres, and Arminio (2014), ensuring credibility, transferability, affirmability, and dependability must be established in qualitative research. To achieve this, we conducted participant interviews and engaged in extensive discussions based on the transcriptions until we came to the conclusion that we did not need any additional data. We confidently assert that the professional ideologies identified by practitioners in higher education are both relevant and credible.

4. Findings

The article's goal, as stated above, was to examine teachers' professional ideologies regarding private higher education in Bangladesh. As the findings suggest, a number of factors, such as diverse understanding of professional ideology, societal perception of private higher education, comparison of private and public higher education influence professional ideologies. In fact, it is important to emphasize that teachers saw private higher education professions as having a mixed concept of professionalism, regardless of their level of experience or institutional differences.

Theme1. Teachers' diverse views on professional ideology

Each participant held their own views to define professional ideology at private higher education in Bangladesh. Participants in this study were university teachers who work at different private universities in Bangladesh. Their perception of professional ideology is quite diverse. The teachers espouse a wide range of ideas, beliefs, principles and ideals that shape their professional ideologies. A sample provided by an associate professor (T-1), who has spent the last 15 years teaching at a private university in Dhaka, the country's capital.

I think a professional ideology is related to a teacher teaching who is time-bound, who as I told you is very friendly but at the same time very strict and honest for classroom teaching; a professionally ideological teacher always responds to students' queries, within the shortest possible time, and, he/she takes part in meetings, attends different training sessions ... symposiums, to develop professionally. (T-1)

Similarly, T-6 stated that it is important to become a resourceful teacher to maintain professional ideology because it helps teachers develop a better communication with students that contributes to establishing trustworthiness, "... Yeah, I think it is commitment, having versatile knowledgeso I need to be able to mentally connect to my students. And ... trustworthiness ... towards my students so that they can trust me. These are the three things." Like T-1, T-6 also felt that a deep knowledge of his/her area of teaching along with integrity for assessing students is essential for developing and practicing professionalism. It was evident when T-6 expressed his view as below:

sure ... hmm ... a deep knowledge in the fieldwisdom ... integrity, so that he will be very honest in assessingin an ethical way ... So if someone possesses all these qualities ... then I will considermaintaining all the professionalism. (T-6)

However, participants felt that developing and practicing professional ideology is not only their individual responsibility but also their

institutional accountability to support them to widen their professional practices. Several interviewees shared common expressions regarding the benefit of institutional support for their professional ideology. A lecturer, T-4, who has 13 years of teaching experience, expressed his view: "Institution also attempts to make the teachers accountable to the profession." Furthermore, Bangladeshi private higher education is still not established enough to support teachers' professional ideology and it is yet appropriate substitute for developing. Interviewees felt that professionalism is essentially necessary for the efficacy of the teaching profession. One of the senior lecturers (T-5) of a reputed university in Dhaka stated that teachers' professional ideology can be like corporate profession where professional ideology should practice independently. It became obvious when T-5, who has nine years of teaching experience shared his viewpoint about professionalism.

Professional ideology is a must for every profession. So, if you are in university teaching, or if you are a corporate, so professionalism is a must. Professional ideology for a teacher I think should cover these areas, like teacher should be regular in the classroom; should be up-to-date about his new curriculum; should be frank; should be honest, and he should not fall in any biasness, and he should be independent ... independent in a sense that he should not judge everyone independently, he should not be biased, or should not be partial to someone. (T-5)

With regard to the priority given by the management of the private higher education in Bangladesh, the teacher participants maintain that the management indirectly tries to commodify higher education that is evident in their market-driven approach. This approach seems to be conflicting with the motto of higher education that stresses enlightening the mind, expanding epistemological horizon, cultivating innovation and creation, and valuing wisdom. However, the teachers feel uncomfortable with this approach of the management, and they expressed that they are often under pressure to cater to students' and parents' satisfaction. For example, T-3 stated:

Sometimes it's very disturbing ... I am asked to do that I don't feel to do. For one thing, it's inflated grading ... otherwise, the students may not continue their study ... they might transfer to other universities, or they might drop out. As a teacher, it is hard to comprise with my professional ethics ... but you know you need a job for survival, so I comply with stuffs that are not supported by my inner being.

It is evident in the comment of T-3 that often time they develop and practice a kind of professional ideology that does not spontaneously emerge from within, but rather it occurs since they need to comply with the employers' pressure and expectations. To add, many people believe that private universities do educational business in the name of teaching. Authorities of these institutions are not concerned about professionalism. For instance, according to T-2, private universities are good "just making money, not ensuring quality education ... So, society has a preference for teachers at a public university, as that is more prestigious. Therefore, one interviewee (T-4) concluded, "They look down upon teachers (Chuckling) who are in private university". It was also apparent during the FGD as several participants pointed it out. For instance, T-7 commented:

It is really hard to cope with the attitude of the authority that is predominantly money-making. Can you imagine a class size of 60 students when it is a language course that expects the teachers to provide the students with individualized attention? I experience frustration since it is hard for me to help students. Moreover, the teachers are heavily hard pressed with irrational teaching load. We often teach 4-5 courses a trimester. Quality of teaching is heavily compromised.

Moreover, another challenging issue of professionalism is the acceptability of Bangladeshi private higher education in the society. It was become clear when T-4 who has been teaching in a private

university for the last thirteen years shared her experiences, “yes, it’s getting more acceptability but when we were students, private universities were looked down upon. You did not get [job] anywhere else and that’s why you got into a private university. But, I think, now, it’s not the case always.”

However, most of the respondents believed that it needs more time to work out on the standard professionalism as private university in Bangladesh is new. The general concept is that these types of higher education institutions have been taking an opportunity of government’s limitation to establish more public universities. The first conception is that. And for that reason, there is a gap. So, without knowing about the private university’s ins and outs, what the opportunities there are, what possibilities there are, without knowing that. It was evident when T-6 expressed his view,

There is a negative attitude to the guardians. So, in the society, that, private universities ... many things are not, actually, in their knowledge. They are not aware of that. We need to work in that. So, if we can go for some different kinds of events, so that the awareness in the guardians, parents, so, that gap can be reduced. T-6

Thus, society may need more time to understand the role of private higher education because it is only two or three generations entering the market. So, when the age of a private university will be 100 years, millions of graduates will be in the market. So, they will, again, give a positive vibe to the job, to the corporate, that, “Yeah, we are capable, at the same time, with the students of the public universities.” So, that will take time. T-5.

It is understandable that interviewees had varied views regarding their opinions of professionalism. While they consider institutional support as one of key factors to develop their professionalism, individual commitment to practice professionalism is necessary. Overall, the results showed that private universities in Bangladesh are subject to a number of restrictions that hinder lecturers’ professionalism. Although lecturers strive to grow their professionalism in accordance with their abilities, institutional shortcomings make standardized practice difficult. It was clearly stated when T-1 shared his view, “I have many limitations obviously, I admit those, and I never say that Okay ... Hmm ... I have contributed a lot, I have created interest in each and every student’s mind about my field.”

Theme 2. Professional ideology as a good teaching practice

The professional ideology of the instructors who work in private universities seems to be the most important topic among all the inquiries. Throughout the interviews, the teachers made a connection between their effective teaching methods and their professional ideologies. The results showed that private university teaching methods had an impact on teachers’ professional ideologies. For them, professional ideology means to maintain the rules and regulations T-1, having fifteen years of experience, stated, “As a teacher, I try to basically maintain the rules and regulations, first of all, of my university. I try to follow the routine, I try to take my tests on time, take my classes on time.” He also believed that having fun while teaching pupils is the best way to practice professionalism. Almost all of the teachers believed that since teaching is our career, there is no doubt that professional philosophy and the personal ideology are intertwined because everything is connected. T-2, teaching at the anthropology department in a well-known private university stated, “Teaching is my profession, so, my professional ideology obviously is not separate from my ideology of my life. Because, I think it is mostly interconnected.” Like T-1 and T-2, other teachers share the same concern. A teacher from a reputed private university in Dhaka said,

Well, I can talk about my professional ideology when it comes to teaching. One thing that I try to do is I try to learn or give something new to my students every semester (T-4).

Yet, it is apparent that the instructors place a strong emphasis on responsibility and accountability, which is a crucial component of

professional ideology. For instance, according to T-5 who has nine years of experience pointed out private university teachers need to maintain certain rules and regulations strictly. He further explained his opinion, “in private university I think there is lot of accountabilities, responsibility, so you cannot exercise that undue influence or power.”

However, some teachers even viewed that professional ideologies would be the same in both the public and private universities although there are dissimilarities in many settings and policies. Hence, regardless of whether you work in public or private higher education, someone should hold all of this. It benefits everyone equally. One thing, though it is crucial, I don’t feel guilty if you don’t feel that way. The professionalism here is that. It was pointed out by T-6,

Actually, professional ideology in both public and private would be the same. The environments are different. And some policies are different, some contexts are different. But ideology should be same.

Thus, it is evident that professional ideology remains consistent across public and private environments, policies, and contexts, regardless of context or environment.

Theme 3. Societal notion of private higher education

All teachers believed that society people have misunderstanding about private higher education in Bangladesh that contributes to creating a gap of understanding the role of teachers. Their initial impression is that private university teachers do not get an opportunity to get other jobs or public universities job. And because of that, there is a divide. Therefore, there is a bad attitude against the guardians because people don’t know the ins and outs of the private institution. The following statement by one teacher is an illustration of this point:

Yes ... “Oh.” Their impression is that he or [she] could not get that chance/opportunity to go there and for that he’s there.” The first conception is that. And for that reason, there is a gap. So, without knowing about the private university’s ins and outs, what the opportunities there are, what possibilities there are, without knowing that, there is a negative attitude to the guardians. So, in the society, that, private universities ... many things are not, actually, in their knowledge. They are not aware of that. We need to work in that. So, if we can go for some different kinds of events, so that the awareness in the guardians, parents, so, that gap can be reduced. (T-1)

Another participant (T-2) echoed the same expression and pointed out the social gap of private higher education when there are socio-economic differences among students of private and public universities. He elaborated, “If you consider students of Dhaka University or any other public university, and that of, you know, IUB and other private universities, obviously it remains an open secret that, in private universities we find students coming from well-off background.” (T2)

However, the teachers also expressed that societal misconception of private higher education has been creating a conflict of teachers’ ideology in private universities in Bangladesh. It was proven when one senior teacher (T-3) who has ten years of experiences in a private university stated there is a misconception regarding the high tuition fee or only upper-class parent’s children studying the private universities in Bangladesh. She highlighted the financial support of private universities students that can reduce the socio-economic gap too.

It both depends, not 100%. Because, even in private university, there we have, if we talk about students from their merits, for example someone who is very meritorious, that student might get a scholarship in private university, when they are studying here. So, but there would be other students who are not really up to the standard, but unfortunately, they are buying their position with money, in private universities. And I don’t think that happens in the government places. So that is, yeah, they are actually getting more privilege. (T-3)

Similarly, it can be concluded that private higher education in Bangladesh encounters many difficulties as it is still young. It is true that

private university students have to pay a lot. So, it is assumed that students come from a rather stable financial situation when they are admitted. When it comes to a student at a public university, this is not always the case. T-4, a senior lecturer of a reputed private university in Dhaka explained this current situation clearly. When the teacher was asked about her opinion regarding private higher education in Bangladesh, she elaborated:

I think because we have a lot of challenges, which private university students do not face. I mean, if you just look at the structure of their payment, they need to pay a lot, private university students, right? So, when they get admitted, it is already granted that they come from quite a stable financial condition. This is not always the case when it comes to a public university student. (T-4)

Thus, because of increased tuition costs and similar factors, lower-income sections of society are excluded from attending private institutions, even though they may come from a wealthier or middle-class portion of society. For instance, T-5, having nine years of experience, stated, “so, definitely, the students from private universities, they may be from richer section or we can call it middle-income section, but the lower-income section of the society don’t have access due to higher tuition fees.” Finally, both have their advantages and disadvantages, in my opinion, but a university education cannot be bad. They are all providing services to hasten the country’s student population’s educational process. It was evidence when T-6 stated:

I think there are of course a lot of pros and cons in both, but no university education can be harmful. They are all rendering services to accelerate the education of students in the country. (T-6)

Therefore, it is evidence that University education offers benefits and cons, but it can be harmful if not used effectively.

5. Discussion

Our findings suggest that teachers’ individual experiences and beliefs influence their perceptions of professional ideology in their professional practices and philosophies. As observed in the themes, teachers emphasize integrity and time management, but there is a perceived conflict between traditional educational values and market-driven institutional interests. These interests include competition, revenue generation, stakeholder pressures, academic freedom, critical thinking, and knowledge creation (Kezar & Bernstein-Sierra, 2023). This conflict is a reflection of larger, worldwide trends in higher education, where institutions are striving to strike a balance between their academic goals and financial viability. Profitability and demands from outside stakeholders are frequently given priority by commercial interests, which may jeopardize academic integrity and the standard of education provided. On the other hand, educational values are essential to the purpose of educational establishments and support the societal objectives of cultural preservation and social mobility. The challenge involves balancing this conflict, making sure that, in the face of market forces to maintain academic integrity and quality, educational values stay at the centre (Kezar & Bernstein-Sierra, 2023; Rumbley et al., 2022). This finding emphasizes the widespread market-driven tendencies affecting higher education globally and is consistent with the current literature on teachers’ professional ideologies (Mok & Marginson, 2021; Rumbley et al., 2022). Our perspective on these findings builds on the critical theories of Apple (2017) and Giroux (2017), who argue that the commercialization of education undermines teachers’ autonomy and the transformative potential of education. Apple (2017) emphasizes that standardized testing and performance metrics prioritize tangible results over the diverse needs of students, which aligns with our findings of the conflict between traditional and educational values and market-driven interests. Giroux (2017) highlights how administrative approaches can hinder innovation and critical engagement, reinforcing our observations about the tension between academic integrity and financial viability.

That is why, participants expressed concern about the necessity of balancing commercial interests with educational values, illustrating the intricate global environment in which higher education functions.

In light of commercialization and public attitudes toward private tertiary education, participants voice concerns about the commercialization of higher education and societal biases against private universities. They express common misconceptions about private higher education in Bangladesh, highlighting the negative perception of university professionals’ jobs and difficulties, which cause division and difficulty in understanding their complexities (Ahmed, 2016). The participants stress the importance of raising awareness to refute the myth that the majority of students attending private universities come from affluent backgrounds. The study highlights teacher disagreements regarding the community’s perception of private higher education and the financial barriers that prevent students from enrolling. The critical discourse should explore the broader implications of cultural biases on the quality of education and the maintenance of social divisions. Misconceptions about private universities can hinder the progress of higher education in Bangladesh by affecting the motivation and satisfaction of professionals. According to our research, opportunities for professional development, job security, and the influence of institutional culture on job satisfaction are all elements that impact teachers’ motivation. Participants in our study voiced concerns about stereotypes regarding the backgrounds of students attending private universities and societal prejudices against these institutions, which affect teachers’ motivation and job satisfaction, as well as their ability to comprehend the complexities of private higher education (Ahmed, 2016). By shedding light on the incentives and challenges faced by educators in private higher education, we hope to raise awareness of the factors influencing educational quality and teacher satisfaction in Bangladesh. Subsequent research endeavors ought to investigate deeper into the complex incentives of faculty members in for-profit higher education establishments and the ramifications for instructional strategies and policies.

The key matter of teachers’ professional ideologies is that private universities in Dhaka charge excessive tuition fees to cover teachers’ high salaries. Some argue that these high salaries make teachers more passionate about their work, but others are concerned that it leads to a decline in the overall standard of education. For instance, according to T-5 and T-6, the negative impacts of high reimbursement, such as teacher burnout, lower standards of instruction, and less time for academic research. Participants in a study expressed concerns about key aspects of a well-rounded higher education program, such as student participation and research, and how financial incentives can heavily impact teaching loads. Therefore, the study raises concerns about the long-term effects of profit-driven practices in private higher education institutions in Bangladesh, which could undermine their main academic goals (Selenica, 2018). By exploring the link between professional ideology and effective teaching strategies among professionals at these institutions, the study emphasizes the importance of adhering to institutional rules and regulations. This importance is further supported by examining the relationship between higher education teachers’ professional ideologies and successful teaching strategies (Hazelkorn, 2015; Pérez-Encinas, 2019). In line with Giroux (2007), our perspective acknowledges that the commercialization of higher education, driven by financial imperatives, can detract from academic freedom and critical pedagogy, which are crucial for fostering meaningful educational experiences.

Regarding professional responsibility in a private higher institution, participants suggest that professional ideology serves as a practical guide for teachers, rather than a theoretical concept (Servage, 2009). Teachers generally believe that professional philosophy should be suitable for private and public higher education institutions, despite contextual differences (Cheng, 2019). The viewpoint provides a comprehensive definition of education professionalism, challenging the notion that institutional differences solely stem from professional ideology. The uniformity of professional ideologies in education can hinder

the adaptability of instructional practices across different institutional contexts due to specific opportunities and limitations. The study explores the impact of institutional rules and professional ideologies on educational creativity and innovation. Apple (2007) also argues that a rigid adherence to standardized practices can stifle creativity and innovation, supporting our findings that professional ideology should be adaptable across different educational contexts.

The interviews with Bangladeshi academics opine a comprehensive understanding of the societal perceptions of private higher education that impacts teachers' professional ideology. The interviews reveal a gap between societal understanding and expectations of private higher education with higher education seen as a means to advance the country (Islam, 2013). The call for comprehensive evaluation, experiential learning, and community involvement in higher education underscores the shared responsibility to align education with national needs (Ahmed, 2016).

In summary, this research contends several noteworthy challenges. Initially, the limited sample size is small, comprising only eight participants from private universities in Dhaka, makes it difficult to apply the results to the entire nation. Second, as a qualitative study, the objective is not to provide statistically representative results. Third, potential bias may have impacted the interview data due to the pre-existing relationship between the researchers and participants. Furthermore, there could be constraints in the subjective interpretation of the findings, influenced by personal biases. Lastly, the main objective of the study was that teachers engaged in teaching at private universities during the study period limit their representation of other universities, such as publicly funded universities.

6. Implication for policy and practice

This study emphasizes the urgent need for policymakers and institutional leaders to wisely navigate the connection of market-driven teaching-learning and professional ideologies in the context of private higher education in Bangladesh. The apparent contradiction between commercial market-based education and conventional educational ideologies, as illuminated by the study (Kezar & Bernstein-Sierra, 2023; Mok & Marginson, 2021; Rumbley et al., 2022), calls for careful policy considerations. Policymakers should carefully address stereotypes about private higher education in light of participants' apprehensions about the market-driven higher education and social prejudices against privatization of higher education (Ahmed, 2016). These stereotypes significantly impact teachers' professional ideologies and teaching practices, often leading to conflicts between commercial profitability and the pursuit of high-quality education. Teachers may find themselves caught between adhering to traditional pedagogical values and adapting to market-driven imperatives, which can impact their effectiveness and students' learning experiences.

Furthermore, this research highlights the effect of cost constraints on student enrolment and the possible long-term consequences of market-driven higher education, otherwise there is a conflict between universities values and market as illustrated by the study (Selenica, 2018). The financial burden on students can lead to reduced access to education, which in turn affects classroom dynamics and the diversity of the student body. Teachers may need to adapt their pedagogical practices to accommodate a wider range of student backgrounds and preparedness levels, which can strain resources and impact educational outcomes. By reducing financial hurdles, students from varied economic backgrounds can have better access to private higher education, thereby enhancing the educational environment and allowing teachers to effectively carry out their professional ideology without compromising on inclusion and quality.

A comprehensive approach to policy formulation is necessary considering the ongoing debate surrounding high tuition fees and their impact on teacher compensation and educational quality (T-5, T-6). Policymakers need to carefully balance the advantages of competitive

remuneration, which can encourage passion and commitment among instructors, against the possible disadvantages, such as lower educational standards and teacher burnout. High tuition costs often increase the financial strain on universities to offer quality education, affecting teachers' workloads and job satisfaction. Therefore, during policy discussions, it is crucial to prioritize finding a balance between academic achievement and financial sustainability. This balance ensures teachers receive fair compensation without compromising instruction quality or putting excessive stress on them, thereby promoting a productive learning environment.

In conclusion, stakeholders, institutional leaders, and legislators must work together to address these ramifications. In the particular context of private higher education in Bangladesh, maintaining the integrity of education while catering to market needs and public expectations requires a smart and balanced approach to policy formulation and execution. Together, these important stakeholders can establish principles that balance educational standards and budgetary limits, allowing private universities to continue offering high-quality instruction while maintaining their financial stability. By investigating teachers' understanding of professional ideologies, this study adds to the body of knowledge by clarifying their influence on pedagogical strategies in the classroom and learning outcomes for students. It emphasizes how crucial it is for teachers' ideologies to correspond with successful teaching practices. Further research is needed to investigate deeper into the ways in which professional ideologies influence classroom practices, thereby enhancing student performance.

7. Limitations

Researchers must recognize the inherent limits of any study. Our research was conducted in a particular setting with unique characteristics and a particular socio-economic background, which probably shaped how our participants viewed and understood private universities and the professional ideologies of teachers. It is crucial to use prudence when extrapolating our conclusions to different situations. Additionally, the sample was limited to familiar individuals, potentially limiting the representation of diverse viewpoints and teacher ideology from those in private institutions. Lastly, the participants' responses to our interview questions may have been influenced by their visible identities.

8. Availability of data and materials

The datasets used and/or analysed during the current study are available from the corresponding author on reasonable request.

Funding

Anhui New Era Education Quality Engineering (Graduate Education) Professional Degree Teaching Case Study "Engineering Management Degree Teaching Case of Leadership with Chinese Characteristics" (2022zyxwjk099); Anhui Province university Excellent Top talent Cultivation Project "Research on Decision-making Model and Improvement Strategy of Interpretable Artificial Intelligent Diagnosis and Treatment" (gxyqZD2022033); Anhui University of Science and Technology major teaching research project "Exploration of Ideological and Political Practice in Economic and Management Courses" (2021xjzdb15).

Ethic statement

I confirm all the subjects have provided appropriate [informed consent](#) and details on how this was obtained are detailed in the manuscript.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Xianmiao Li: Writing – original draft, Formal analysis. **M. Monjurul Islam:** Visualization, Supervision. **Shaiful Islam:** Methodology, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Xianwei Gao:** Writing – review & editing, Resources. **Zhu Rong:** Supervision, Visualization.

Declaration of competing interest

I declare that there are no conflicts of interest associated with this research.

Data availability

Data will be made available on request.

Acknowledgements

We would like to give our heartiest thanks to all the participants of this study.

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